The Dissertation as Orthopraxy

Examination, Citation, and the Legal Form of Access

Abstract and statement of method

Pissarro, Paul-Alexander Arthur
ORCID iD 0009-0000-0830-8438

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Abstract

Scholarship registers contribution by citation. A dissertation is examined before it can be cited. What is certified at examination is therefore a forecast of contribution rather than contribution itself. This study sets that proposition against three bodies of evidence, historical, experimental and procedural, and then acts on the result.

The first is historical. The European degree ladder is a transposed craft-guild structure in which master and doctor were originally synonymous, both naming the *licentia docendi*, the licence to teach, neither certifying an original contribution to knowledge. The definition of the doctorate as certifying new knowledge is a modern retrofit, as the historiography of the German university has established: Humboldt's memorandum of 1810, the document usually credited with the research ideal, was left a fragment, went unpublished in his lifetime, and first appeared in print in 1903, and the attribution of the ideal to Humboldt is itself a twentieth-century invention. What has not been drawn from that record is its general form: a legitimating origin can be composed long after the fact, and the institution it explains runs unchanged either way.

The second is experimental. A hypnotic induction is the ritual preamble, ordinarily relaxation and fixed attention, held to produce the state in which suggestion works. When identical suggestions are administered with and without one, the induction contributes little to measured response, on the order of one and a half suggestions in ten. What governs the account the subject gives is not the procedure but its name: a

conventional induction introduced as a control produces less than half the depth it produces under its own name, while white noise introduced as hypnosis produces as much as the real thing. The ceremony does not produce the capacity. It relocates its authorship.

The third is procedural. Entry to the principal scholarly indexes is conditioned on the legal form of the depositor rather than on the assessed quality of the work. The index of record for dissertations accepts them only from institutions it recognises as accredited. The principal humanities archive states that it does not publish what it hosts. The registry through which citations are counted admits organisations and not individuals, and an unaffiliated author reaches them only from inside a repository that supplies the standing they lack. The exclusion of unaffiliated scholars is well documented; what follows from it is not. A gate set on legal form rather than merit is satisfied by incorporation rather than by better work, and a gate that cheap screens for nothing it claims to screen for.

The argument is not that examination is worthless. Pre-circulation scrutiny catches error before it propagates, which no citation count can do. Rather, two functions, quality assurance and the registration of contribution, have been fused in one instrument and can be separated. Drawing on the history of the university, on artistic precedents for the self-constituted institution, on Adorno on theory as praxis, and on the performative utterance, it asks what it would mean to register a contribution without certifying it in advance. What emerges is an account of the doctorate as a forecast, and a demonstration of the alternative: a work constituted rather than petitioned, deposited under a persistent identifier, and submitted to a citation record published openly and dated before the first deposit.

Keywords

orthopraxy; credentialism; doctoral education; history of universities; Humboldt myth; suggestion and response expectancy; scholarly indexing; independent scholars; institutional repositories; open access; artistic research

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